

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Volcanic eruption

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Follow the local volcano evacuation order and stay out of restricted zones. If ash is falling and you are not told to evacuate, stay indoors with windows and doors closed. Avoid river valleys where volcanic mudflows may travel.

Do now.

**Check official monitoring**

01

Use local emergency alerts and the responsible volcano observatory.

**Leave danger zones**

02

Take designated evacuation routes; do not approach the volcano to watch.

**Limit ash exposure**

03

Close outside-air openings and use eye protection and a well-fitting particulate respirator for necessary outdoor movement.

**Keep roads clear**

04

Avoid driving in ash unless necessary; visibility and engines can be affected.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Keep away from river valleys, exclusion areas and visible ash plumes. Use the best reachable intact shelter for ashfall while checking evacuation information. Avoid driving through heavy ash unless leaving a more immediate threat; ash can impair engines and visibility.

Watch for.

A particle respirator does not protect against volcanic gases.

People & practical needs.

Account for children, older people, pets and anyone who needs assistance before moving. Keep shoes, medicines and a torch in the shelter area. Decide who helps whom and who carries the essential supplies; do not send a lone child to retrieve items. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: check official monitoring. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. A particle respirator does not protect against volcanic gases.

Keep essentials within reach.

For volcanic eruption, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Keep away from river valleys, exclusion areas and visible ash plumes. Use the best reachable intact shelter for ashfall while checking evacuation information. Avoid driving through heavy ash unless leaving a more immediate threat; ash can impair engines and visibility. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Wait for reentry instructions. Do not climb a roof covered in ash; wet ash can overload structures.

First decision: Check official monitoring

Use local emergency alerts and the responsible volcano observatory. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Keep away from river valleys, exclusion areas and visible ash plumes. Use the best reachable intact shelter for ashfall while checking evacuation information. Avoid driving through heavy ash unless leaving a more immediate threat; ash can impair engines and visibility. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

A particle respirator does not protect against volcanic gases. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Follow the local volcano evacuation order and stay out of restricted zones. If ash is falling and you are not told to evacuate, stay indoors with windows and doors closed. Avoid river valleys where volcanic mudflows may travel. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For volcanic eruption, keep the specific hazard in view: A particle respirator does not protect against volcanic gases.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Keep roads clear. Avoid driving in ash unless necessary; visibility and engines can be affected. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Volcanic eruption · official guidance

<https://www.ready.gov/volcanoes>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/volcanic-eruption/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.